CHRIS ULLMANN

From Air Force Flight Lines to Fortune 500 AI Transformation

I've spent 25 years doing the same thing in different wrappers: walking into complex systems, building the solution, and getting people to run with it. That started on Air Force flight lines and evolved into FDA compliance turnarounds, a $49M enterprise transformation, and now driving AI product development from concept through deployment, partnering with IT and providers like Microsoft to deliver tools people actually use. I build the strategy, the governance, the adoption frameworks, and the products. The numbers tell the story.

EXPERIENCE

The Estee Lauder Companies

New York, NY

Executive Director, AI Transformation and NA MFG Strategy — 2024 - Present

- Built and run North America's Manufacturing Strategy and Transformation Office: **60 projects, ~$100M annual investment, 5 plants**
- Drove end-to-end AI product development, partnering with IT and Microsoft to take solutions from concept through pilot to enterprise rollout, including "Plant Perfect" (KPI analytics) and "ELLA" (line-level AI assistant)
- Built ground-up adoption program rooted in Kotter's Leading Bold Change: grew active AI users **30% month-over-month** (37x in 9 months) across a **100+ member Community of Practice**
- Activated **1,000+ people** on AI, taking them from first exposure to daily use; presented the ELLA use case at **Microsoft Ignite**
- Co-developed governance frameworks with Legal, Compliance, and value streams before scaling tools, achieving **zero compliance incidents**

Executive Director, PMO, Supply Chain and Digital Transformation — 2018 - 2024

- Managed Program Runway: **$49M+ enterprise value chain transformation, 170% ROI**, 6 workstreams across MAC, Clinique, Estee Lauder, Bobbi Brown, Tom Ford
- Program managed **$13.3M Engineering Tech Center** build; deployed digital printing and small-batch manufacturing capabilities
- Authored and sponsored **$500M+ Integrated Manufacturing Transformation** roadmap: 4 workstreams, 20+ projects
- Led business requirements and delivery of the **$16.1M Runway Platform** with EPAM: a custom NPL system that consolidated 30+ brand launch processes into one enterprise platform, enabling portfolio-level insights that aligned product innovation to brand positioning and reduced same-shelf competition
- Delivered **$1.4M run-rate savings** from automation and cobots; $7M destruction cost avoidance

Executive Director, Quality Assurance — 2015 - 2018

- Reduced lab testing cycle time from **12 days to 2.7 days** (80% reduction), releasing **$3.75M per month ($45M/year)** in working capital
- Achieved **90% reduction in audit observations** through organizational redesign and quality systems modernization
- Led global redesign: quality control to quality assurance mindset

CONTACT

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KEY METRICS

1,000+ PEOPLE ACTIVATED ON AI	**170%** ROI ON $49M PROGRAM
$45M WORKING CAPITAL RELEASED	**80%** CYCLE TIME REDUCTION
$500M+ TRANSFORMATION AUTHORED	**90%** AUDIT OBS. REDUCED

EXPERTISE

- AI Strategy, Development and Delivery
- Generative AI / Agent Architecture
- AI Governance and Compliance
- Manufacturing Operations
- Supply Chain Transformation
- Quality (GMP, FDA, 21 CFR)
- Program and Portfolio Mgmt
- Change Mgmt (Kotter 8-Step)
- Digital Transformation
- Lean Six Sigma
- Stakeholder Alignment

EDUCATION

Stanford School of Engineering
Generative AI: Technology, Business and Society Program

Queens University of Charlotte
B.S. Biology

CERTIFICATIONS

- Lean Six Sigma
- Leading Bold Change (Kotter)

Coty Inc.

Phoenix, AZ / Sanford, NC

Director, Quality Assurance — 2013 - 2015

- Owned quality and compliance workstream for **$21.7M multi-site consolidation**: $39M first-year savings, full operation transfer (AZ to NC)
- Optimized 70-person quality org to 42 (40% reduction) with **39% productivity gain**
- Built FDA compliance program: gap assessment, action planning, 18-30 month remediation roadmap

> *Featured in Harvard Business Review: "How Coty Reinvigorated Its Supply Chain" (May 2016)*

Manager / Senior Manager, QA Operations and QC Labs — 2011 - 2013

- Implemented GMP/QMS systems from scratch; **60% reduction** in supplier quality incidents
- Led integration of 100M-unit Nail Lacquer business from acquisition

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Harmony Labs / EI Pharmaceutical, Charlotte, NC 2008 - 2011
QA and Validation Manager, cosmetic-to-pharmaceutical GMP transformation, primary FDA liaison

Leiner Health Products, Fort Mill, SC 2003 - 2007
Master Planner / QA Supervisor. Reduced quarantine inventory from $16M to under $200K across 5 plants.

United States Air Force (1992 - 1996) · Aerospace Ground Equipment Technician
Edwards AFB, CA and Incirlik Air Base, Turkey · Operation Provide Comfort II
Two Air Force Achievement Medals · Honorable Discharge · **Protected Veteran**